

Animal relationships

ANIMALS LIVE TOGETHER IN DIFFERENT WAYS.

Competition for resources is central to animal life. Many species go it alone, but others team up to make life easier. This teaming-up may be between members of the same species, or involve completely different animals working together.

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Social groups

The strongest competition for survival is between members of the same species. Solitary animals avoid each other, so that competition is at a minimum. The animals that live in groups must strike a balance between the benefits of sticking together, and the increased competition for food and mates. Social groups range from simple ones that provide safety in numbers, to complex societies, where members hunt together and protect each other's young.



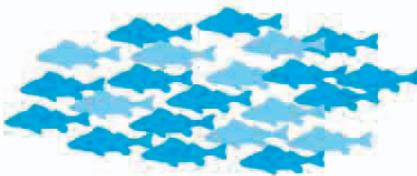
△ Lion pride

Prides feature one top male, who protects the rest and fathers all the cubs.



△ Wolf pack

Wolves work together to hunt animals much larger than themselves.



△ Fish school

Within a school, an individual has less chance of being picked off by a predator.



△ Sheep flock

Together, a flock is more likely to spot a threat before it gets too close.

A single **super colony** of Argentine ants runs 6,000 km (3,700 miles) along the southern European coast.



△ Baboon troop

Baboons work together to defend their young and secure food supplies.



△ Okapi

Living alone is best in a dense forest habitat where food is widely available.

Eusocial colony

The most highly social animals are ants, wasps, and bees. They are eusocial, which means there is division of labour, with different members of the colony performing specific jobs for the good of the whole. The colony works for their mother, the queen, to raise huge numbers of yet more sisters. All work is done by females. Only a few males are produced every year to mate with the next generation of queens.

woodcutter ants feed on fungus grown on a compost of cut leaf fragments



△ Forager

Foragers collect food from the surroundings and bring it back to the nest for the colony to eat.

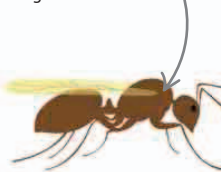
eggs develop into more workers to help out in the colony



△ Worker

Small workers feed and clean the eggs, larvae, and pupae, and help build the nest.

queen is considerably larger than other ants



△ Queen

A large female controls the colony, and uses chemicals to stop other females from laying eggs.

wings used to fly to find a mate



△ Male

Male ants are produced at the end of summer. They die after they have mated with a queen.